into steely, consistent winners, and he was not too concerned if lesser men were upset along the way.

Graeme was easy to follow because he led from the front. He could be severe, not hesitating to let us know when our performance fell below required standards, but he could also be gentle and encouraging. On a personal level, he always backed me and believed in me. I can't explain how much that meant to me. In tough times, when many were ready to dismiss me as too loose, his unwavering support helped me bounce back.

Biff wasn't tough in every respect; in fact, he was and probably remains terrified of ghosts, a reality that prompted me to have some fun at his expense during the days when we were preparing to play the third Test match against India in Kanpur during November 2008.

We were both staying on the third floor of the hotel but I was allocated a standard room while, as captain, he was given a luxury suite that included his own living room and bedroom. Looking around one evening, I realised it would be only slightly dangerous to climb out of my window, step onto the narrow ledge and then climb through the window of his living room and so gain access to his suite.

I attempted to execute this manoeuvre, only to discover the latch of his window was firmly locked. Undeterred, I climbed back to my room, knocked on his door and pretended to be making a social call, asking him how he was doing, complimenting him on the suite, and discreetly loosening the latch on the window.

The stage was set and, later that same night, when I was sure he was in bed, I set off again, climbed out my window and in through his, and successfully reached his living room. I proceeded to move a few pictures around on the wall and to switch on the television, turning the volume up high, and then hid behind a curtain. Graeme leapt up and rushed through from his bedroom to look around. Seeing nothing, he switched off the TV and returned to bed. When all was clear, I climbed back out of the window and silently returned to my room.